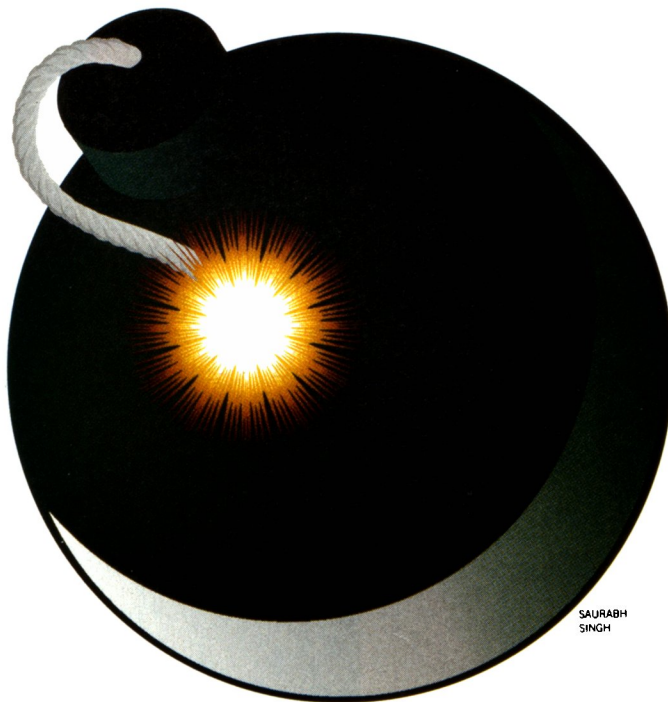


madrasa at Kantharia near Bharuch called Darul Uloom Arabiyyah Islamiyyah. (These madrasas have now stopped enrolling Kashmiri students following police pressure). It is possible that the blasts were the work of these new recruits.

Significantly, one of the most notorious commanders of HUI and leader of its Auragabad module, Javed Kashmiri, who is eluding Maharashtra Police, had his religious education in a similar madrasa near Bharuch. The 101-year-old Deobandi madrasa at Dabhel near Surat, which is the oldest Deobandi madrasa in Gujarat, has also been accused of spreading radicalism. At least two maulvis charged with terrorist acts have studied in Dabhel.

In Gujarat, almost all those arrested in relation to terror acts following the post-Godhra riots, including the infamous Akshardham attack and the lesser known bus bomb blasts in 2002 in which 13 people were injured, were Deobandis. So, it came as no surprise last week when the police arrested a radical Ahle Hadis maulvi, Abdul Halim, within hours of the Ahmedabad blasts.



**Ahmedabad blasts are a result of big intelligence lapse on the part of the state police since a large number of locals are believed to be involved.**

Halim faces an old but unsubstantiated charge that he had sent some boys to Pakistan for arms training following the Gujarat riots.

The emails follow a recurring theme—that Indian Muslims had decided to take the offensive way to waging a jihad. They refer to the severe penalties awarded to the accused in the Mumbai blasts of March 1993, lack of action against Hindu police officers who allegedly committed atrocities on Muslims, the Gujarat riots of 2002, the assault on arrested JEM suspects by some lawyers and, that the criminal justice system treated the Muslims severely but was lenient with the Hindus.

How to identify terrorists without hurting the community—recruitment aspect for terrorists—is a challenge before law enforcement officials. One officer who had mastered this technique after acquiring sound knowledge of the working of the Wahhabi tanzeems was Gujarat Police DIG D.G. Vanzara, who was in-charge of the state Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS). He had reportedly made life miserable for the ultra radical Wahhabis in Gujarat during his tenure. This process screeched to a halt when he was arrested in the Sohrabuddin encounter case along with two other IPS officers and 11 other policemen in June 2007.

Though controversial, Vanzara had, on the

basis of his knowledge and skill, raised his own intelligence network within the Muslim community by roping in the moderate elements even in the Wahhabi tanzeems. He used this information to monitor the tanzeems. One of his unorthodox techniques was keeping the relatives of absconding terror act accused under his personal custody till the accused presented himself before the police. Unorthodox measures they may have been, but they succeeded in keeping radical Islamic elements on a tight leash. Vanzara's acts, though, were often interpreted as harassment of the Muslim community, while in effect these were necessary measures to prevent terror attacks, say police officials. Many see last week's attack as a result of a big intelligence lapse on the part of the state police, since a very large number of locals are believed to be involved.

The absence of Vanzara was clearly visible even in the Ahmedabad blast investigation last week. Despite suspecting the involvement of a large number of locals in the terror act, the police picked up only Halim.

As a police official puts: "Following such incidents, the net has to be cast wide. The unwanted fish can be released back into the lake while retaining the wanted ones." Clearly, for law enforcement agencies, caution is the new watch word. ■